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Labor and Liturgy

Virgil Michel and a Liturgical Theology of Meaningful Work

INTRODUCTION

Meaningful work can be difficult to find in the United States. As many as 9 out of 10 US employees would take a pay cut in order to access more meaningful work,¹ but workplaces are often ill-equipped to reckon with that kind of demand. As with nearly any issue facing the workplace in the US, a small industry has taken shape to address the problem, studying what kinds of meaning can be efficiently crafted in work, and how to effectively produce workplaces that do so.² By this I do not mean to impugn good-faith efforts to find meaning in one's everyday labor; rather, from a Christian perspective, the meaning of one's work does not simply derive from feelings of satisfaction or the fulfillment of one's personal preferences. Instead, this discussion argues that infusion of meaning into the work of Christians can be best thought of as a symbolic, ritual process, anchored in the liturgical constitution of the church as the mystical body of Christ. To arrive at that conclusion, the discussion begins by retrieving a theology of the mystical body of Christ as it takes shape in the thought of Virgil Michel, OSB, whose work on the relationship between the liturgical and social spheres of life played an essential, formative role in the North American Liturgical Movement and its impact. After outlining Michel's approach to mystical body of Christ theology, the discussion

¹ Shawn Achor, Andrew Reece, Gabriella Rosen Kellerman, and Alexi Robichaux, "9 Out of 10 People Are Willing to Earn Less Money to Do More-Meaningful Work," *Harvard Business Review*, November 6, 2018, accessed June 11, 2021, <https://hbr.org/2018/11/9-out-of-10-people-are-willing-to-earn-less-money-to-do-more-meaningful-work>.

² See, for example, the study and offerings of the firm BetterUp: <https://www.betterup.com/>.

moves to taking account of what Michel saw as the major factor inhibiting the integration of the liturgical and social realities of the mystical body of Christ: American bourgeois individualism. The antidote to this poison, Michel was convinced, could be found in liturgical practice, specifically the symbolic self-offering of the assembly to the service of God as the mystical body of Christ (this movement comprises the third section of this discussion). Finally, the discussion concludes by placing Michel's insights in the contemporary US social and theological context, and suggests concrete liturgical-theological steps toward realizing Michel's integrative vision of liturgy and labor, toward a liturgical theology of meaningful work.

LITURGY AND THE MYSTICAL BODY OF CHRIST

The concept of Christ's mystical body is the cornerstone upon which Virgil Michel builds his understanding of the relationship between liturgy and all other areas of life, including labor. It is as the mystical body of Christ that the church relates to the world and its operations, and it is as that one mystical body that the members of the church are bound together when they celebrate liturgy. The key for Michel is that the mystical body does not dissolve when the assembly is sent forth at the end of the liturgical celebration; instead, the body simply changes positions, from prayer to work. Christ's mystical body, for Michel, is not transient or episodic. It is the enduring mode of existence for the church in the world, and it resists any fragmentation or compartmentalization of the lives of Christians individually and collectively. What the mystical body of Christ celebrates in the liturgy, for Michel, it must strive to embody when it departs the liturgical assembly.

Theologies of the mystical body of Christ are often treated as ecclesiologies, and indeed a number of scholars have read Michel's use of mystical body theology as primarily ecclesiological,³ but to do so tends to miss or downplay its fundamentally social aspects. There are certainly approaches to mystical body theology that treat the concept as primarily ecclesiological, but for

³ See Jeremy Hall, *The Full Stature of Christ: The Ecclesiology of Virgil Michel*, OSB (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1976), or David W. Fagerberg, "Liturgy, Social Justice, and the Mystical Body of Christ: The Vision of Virgil Michel," *Letter and Spirit* 5 (2009): 193–210.

Michel, ecclesiology tends to grow as a consequence of what is primarily a sacramental theology of the mystical body of Christ. I am not unique in this reading of Michel. Timothy Gabrielli, for example, has argued (correctly I think) that the theology of the mystical body of Christ “was the fundamental theological category from which Michel’s integrated Catholic vision of liturgical and social action flowed.”⁴ For Michel, the question of how Christians are to pray and work is the question of how the mystical body of Christ is to pray and work. All the concepts of solidarity, the common good, social justice, and the relationships of these to Christian liturgy that so characterized the North American Liturgical Movement⁵ ultimately spring, for Michel, from understanding the church as the mystical body of Christ.⁶

Michel’s conception of the mystical body of Christ as fundamental for the integration of liturgical and social life did not coalesce in a vacuum. Gabrielli traces its roots to what he calls the “French-speaking socio-liturgical stream of mystical body of Christ theology,”⁷ and agrees with H. A. Reinhold that Michel then “made it as American as only an American mind could make it.”⁸ I do not dispute these readings of Michel, but for the purposes of this discussion, there is another relevant aspect of Michel’s theology that makes the mystical body of Christ so important for his theological vision. For Michel, writing in the early-twentieth-century United States, mystical body of Christ theology provided a potent counter to a prevailing model of social and economic life in his context: that of the machine, the parts of which are run by individual operators. For Michel, “we must at last get away from the notion . . . that the money system is an automatic machinery which operates accord-

⁴ Timothy R. Gabrielli, *One in Christ: Virgil Michel, Louis-Marie Chauvet, and Mystical Body Theology* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2017), 51.

⁵ For Michel’s own summary explanation of the Liturgical Movement, see Virgil Michel, “The Liturgical Movement,” *American Ecclesiastical Review* 78, no. 2 (1928): 136–42.

⁶ Even in Michel’s time, however, terms like “social justice” were becoming problematic to use in relation to liturgy, and he spent considerable energy explaining and defending how he envisioned them. See, for example, Virgil Michel, “Social Justice,” *Orate Fratres* 12, no. 4 (1938): 129–32.

⁷ Gabrielli, *One in Christ*, 51.

⁸ H. A. Reinhold, quoted in Gabrielli, 70.

ing to rigid natural economic laws.”⁹ Economic and social life, for Michel, is a matter of the shared body, a conviction which comes from his reading of *Quadragesimo Anno* (Pius XI’s encyclical on the social and economic orders),¹⁰ and so to hold fast to mystical body theology provides much-needed theological resistance to a default view of economics and society as primarily mechanical. The vitality of the social body depends upon the different parts relating to one another in ways that promote the life of the whole,¹¹ which is entirely different from a machine whose operation depends simply on correct working parts and competent operators.

Michel’s centralizing of mystical body of Christ theology is more than only a theological move; it is also a liturgical-catechetical move. Adequately teaching the theology of the mystical body of Christ, to say nothing of then forming Christians to embody it in their social and/or economic worlds, is a task that runs beyond the capability of only religious instruction or theological education. These aspects are important, but for Michel, the primary way for Christians to “learn” the mystical body of Christ is to be formed by Christian liturgy, which constitutes it. The entire symbolic system of rituals within Christianity serves to provide a kind of mediation of the reality of the mystical body of Christ to the members of that body, a level of instruction that discourse alone simply cannot achieve. And yet a kind of instruction it does remain. As Michel argues, “the liturgy is not only the source of divine life or grace, not only the divine inspiration to put forth generous effort towards the growth of the kingdom of God in souls, but also the divine school of the formation of our minds in the way of Christ.”¹² For Michel, learning to live as the mystical body of Christ is already primarily a bodily process—it begins with celebrating Christian liturgy together.¹³ Christ’s mystical body is built in the liturgy, and it learns to live in the liturgy.

⁹ Virgil Michel, *Christian Social Reconstruction* (Milwaukee, WI: Bruce Publishing, 1937), 60.

¹⁰ See especially Michel, *Christian Social Reconstruction*, 51–53, and 91–107.

¹¹ This is developed more fully in the next section below.

¹² Virgil Michel, “Back to the Liturgy,” *Orate Fratres* 11, no. 1 (1936): 13.

¹³ See, for example, Virgil Michel, “Teaching the Life of Christ,” *Orate Fratres* 15, no. 1 (1940): 12–17.

BOURGEOIS INDIVIDUALISM

If for Michel mystical body of Christ theology is a corrective against living as if the social and economic realms work primarily like a great set of machines, it is worthwhile to understand what Michel sees as feeding that problem. For Michel, individualism is the great evil that disintegrates shared social, economic, and religious bodies. The image of disintegration here is intentional, and I mean it as an actual ripping-apart, not simply a synonym for destruction. The social, economic, and religious parts of life should be integrated in the mystical body of Christ, but when individualism holds sway, integrated life dissolves and the mystical body disintegrates. This focus on individualism likely does not come as a great surprise, given that the problems with individualism have been a consistent subject of theological inquiry for quite a while, but in Michel's view, a particular kind of individualism that has specific characteristics comprises an especially potent catalyst for the disintegration of the mystical body of Christ: bourgeois individualism, built upon illusory self-sufficiency.

In Michel's view, individualism has its alluring, rotten core in the myth of self-sufficiency. For him, "the basic principle of this individualism is that each [human being] is to all intents and purposes sufficient unto [themselves]."¹⁴ The most basic and blessed state of the human then is, in this view, to be wholly autonomous and independent from outside needs or influences. Failing that, the individual human should at least be free to choose which influences to entertain, and which to reject. Humans then are each one a whole individually, who can consume discrete parts of their contexts according to their preferences. Because one is a self-sufficient whole, one's economic activities need not have anything to do with one's religious activities, one's political preferences need not converse with one's religious convictions, and one's social actions can be completely separate from one's religious life. Such disintegration of life leads to potent and tragic examples of Christian hypocrisy. Referring to African-American converts to Christianity in his context, Michel notes, "they enter into membership of the mystical body with all the fervent love and appreciation of the newly baptized, and they are shocked to find little response

¹⁴ Michel, *Christian Social Reconstruction*, 9.

in the way of fraternal love or even of interest on the part of the fellowship they have joined.”¹⁵ The mystical body ceases to be a body as individualism allows for separating the otherwise-integrated aspects of one’s life, and injustice invariably follows.

Individualism’s power to disintegrate life poses a general threat to Christians’ living as Christ’s mystical body, but Michel names a specific characteristic of individualism in his context that exacerbates that threat: individualism as bourgeois. While a critique of bourgeois individualism might strike an odd key in the United States church today, Michel’s terminology in this carries with it a meaning that has lost no relevance for the contemporary United States. For Michel, what makes individualism “bourgeois” is the operative conviction that what one needs (or what one is due) is *more* than a livelihood. What one needs is ever-increasing profit.¹⁶ Michel calls this the “bourgeois spirit,” for which “wealth alone counts.”¹⁷ Such a concentration on monetary gain combines with individualism’s myth of self-sufficiency in order to synthesize an approach to life that does not just disintegrate aspects of Christians’ lives from one other; it disintegrates the very body of Christ by separating Christians from one another into competing entities uninterested in the wellbeing of one another. In Michel’s words, “the spirit of individual profit-seeking is one that frankly fosters egoism, especially when it is sponsored in the name of a free-for-all struggle among [people] who should be cooperating as [siblings] and should have some care one of the other because of their common membership in the human family.”¹⁸

The relentless pursuit of profit that characterizes bourgeois individualism makes necessary for its adherents, in Michel’s view, absolute permission for competition with one another. When fellow members of the mystical body of Christ are reduced from siblings to competitors, no aspects of their lives are

¹⁵ Virgil Michel, “Our Social Environment,” *Orate Fratres* 12, no. 7 (1938): 318.

¹⁶ Virgil Michel, “The Bourgeois Spirit and Christian Renewal,” *Orate Fratres* 14, no. 6 (1940): 253–60.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, 258.

¹⁸ Virgil Michel, “Critique of Capitalism,” in *The Social Question*, series V (St. Paul, MN: Wanderer, 1937), 14.

insulated from that competition. Since the myth of individualism holds each person to be free and self-sufficient, no consideration other than competitive power and advantage need be afforded to anyone. Michel notes that this “cut-throat struggle for existence, or rather struggle for increase of wealth, in which all [people] are theoretically at liberty to take part,”¹⁹ ultimately concentrates economic means and power in fewer and fewer hands. As the mystical body disintegrates, it eats itself away.

At this point our discussion can turn specifically to the issue of labor, because for Michel, one of the tragedies of bourgeois individualism’s disintegration of the mystical body of Christ is that the concept of a “just wage” becomes as foreign as the concept of just prices for raw materials or goods. Since the bourgeois spirit pursues profit above all else, the price of goods and materials is wholly separated from considerations of ethics and justice. All that matters is the principle of free bargaining, and what someone is willing to pay. “Unfortunately, but very logically,” Michel notes, “the principle is extended to the hiring of the laborers necessary for industrial production or other work. Labor is reduced to a commodity of the market.”²⁰ If this claim sounds overly obvious, it stands as a testament to just how strongly this bourgeois individualism holds captive our conceptions of labor and the market.

For Michel, however, labor is not reducible to a commodity. Labor is exertion by a particular person, and as such it is inseparable from that person’s belonging in a social body. As Michel’s intended audience is overwhelmingly other Catholics, this insight extends to his recognition that labor is inseparable from the member of the body of Christ who does it. As such, “buying” labor and “selling” labor are incongruous terms for Michel; labor is not the same kind of thing as goods or materials. Goods and materials are things that can be privately owned and transferred, but “all ownership originally and basically rests on personal human effort and energy.”²¹ Labor for Michel cannot be

¹⁹ Virgil Michel, “The Nature of Capitalism,” in *Economics and Finance*, book 2 of *The Social Problem* (Collegeville, MN: Saint John’s Abbey, 1936), 17.

²⁰ *Ibid.*, 18.

²¹ Virgil Michel, *The Christian in the World* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1942), 96. Italics removed. For Michel, this is more than simply a logical connection between

separated from the laborer; such an action dehumanizes both the laborer and the one who purports to purchase the labor, because both belong to the same body.

In this light, Michel sees significant danger in parts of human life that work to separate labor from the laborer. Increased mechanization, ever-increasing reliance on financial systems that stray further and further from labor, and over-industrialization in which workers may never actually witness the fruits of their labor, all contribute to stepwise disintegration of labor from the laborer in the mystical body of Christ.²² These aspects of economic life are not necessarily evil on their own, but they tend to obscure the humanity of persons who share in this economic life, the humanity which is the basis for fundamental rights,²³ and which is shared by the rest of the social, economic, and ecclesial body. For Michel, the health of the social body is bolstered when labor and its fruits are not treated as irrelevant to one another. Instead, the works of bodies within the social (and ecclesial) body are made meaningful by their connection to those bodies whose labor crafted them, and those bodies who then receive and make use of those works. In short, the mystical body of Christ works *together*, or it disintegrates.

LABOR AND LITURGY

It may be tempting at this point to reduce Michel's insights about labor to those of any number of other figures who have argued similar positions from the perspectives of economics, philosophy, politics, or other disciplines. However, to do so would be to miss Michel's fundamental point in speaking about labor: the worth of labor and the necessary justice appropriate to it derive from living as the mystical body of Christ. Justice in labor is vocational to the Christian; labor cannot be put aside as a non-religious matter. Labor

labor and ownership; it derives from the theological import of goods for fulfilling the moral life (Virgil Michel, *Purpose and Duty of Ownership* [St. Louis, MO: Central Bureau, C. C. V. of A., 1935], 5).

²² See, for example, Virgil Michel, "Agriculture and Reconstruction," *Commonweal* 29, no. 12 (1939): 317–18.

²³ Virgil Michel, "The Basis of Human Rights," in *Social Concepts and Problems*, book 1 of *The Social Problem* (Collegeville, MN: Saint John's Abbey, 1936), 33–37.

justice is essentially religious for Michel, not incidentally so. As such, it is the role of religious practice to form the minds of Christians toward this justice, toward the mind of Christ.

In Michel's view, formation of Christians' approaches to labor through the practice of liturgy is about more than just educating individual Christians about the ways by which their own labor participates in the mystical body of Christ, or about how Christian employers should treat their workers. That is certainly part of what the liturgy can assist with (helping those gathered to see more clearly the mystical body of Christ and the ways it relates to and through the world), but liturgy forms more than individual Christians for engagement with society. It forms the whole assembly, and the church itself beyond the local assembly. Additionally, this liturgical formation for social life is not simply about the actions of individual Christians within society; it is about the actions of the whole mystical body of Christ in its society. Liturgical formation for both particular Christians *and* for the whole Christian community are two sides of the same coin. This closely mirrors labor for Michel: "Since labor is both individually and socially necessary, the responsibility for upholding the proper conditions of labor and of the laborers is not only an individual one but a social one."²⁴

Such a mixture of the individual and communal characters of both liturgy and labor (and really all of social life) for Michel is one reason he sees the practice of liturgy as fertile ground for cultivating Christian action for social justice. As Michel sees it, Christian worship in the context of liturgy should organically translate into a whole life of worship,²⁵ and this again not simply as particular Christians but as the Christian community living in its social contexts. However, to maintain that such a translation should be "organic" is not the same as claiming that it should be somehow magically accomplished. Even organic processes are exactly that—processes—and they tend to proceed using particular and often predictable modes and actions.

²⁴ Michel, *Christian Social Reconstruction*, 34.

²⁵ Keith F. Pecklers, *The Unread Vision: The Liturgical Movement in the United States of America: 1926–1955* (Collegetown, MN: Liturgical Press, 1998), 133.

This bridging process or action for Michel—the one that connects Christians celebrating liturgy to their workplace selves—is the action of sacrifice, understood as self-offering. I realize that the concept of sacrifice, and in particular the liturgical “sacrifice of the mass,” is a neuralgic area in a number of theological fields, but the way that Michel understands the action of sacrifice tends to sidestep much of that neuralgia.²⁶ For Michel, sacrifice is essentially an offering, and the matter of the eucharistic sacrifice in particular—the bread and wine offered—makes symbolically real the self-offering of Christians to God:

The offering of bread and wine symbolizes most beautifully the complete offering of self to God, one’s whole life, all of one’s energies, even unto the daily trials and hardships. Not only that. It represents also the offering of oneself as a member of Christ, in union with one’s fellow members.²⁷

It is worthwhile to note that Michel connects this self-offering to God in a special way to the labor practices of Christians, because “bread and wine also symbolize human energy and labor in a special degree . . . they well stand for human labor.”²⁸ In this way, while the entire created order stands as a potential sacramental bridge between the human and the divine,²⁹ the particular symbols of bread and wine, coupled with the particular symbolizing action of sacrifice in the context of liturgy, provide a framework for integrating (or re-integrating) the mystical body of Christ that is so disintegrated by bourgeois individualism.

Beyond the particular liturgical symbols that catalyze the integration of Christians’ liturgical and work lives, Michel is not content to leave this integrative process to liturgical hopefulness. Just as liturgy cannot be separated from the labor of those assembled for it, liturgical theology cannot abdicate its social role. The social implications of liturgical theology need not be dictatorial as if

²⁶ A full discussion of how Michel understands sacrifice runs beyond the scope of this article, so we will limit the explanation to a brief summary here.

²⁷ Virgil Michel, *Our Life in Christ* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1939), 98.

²⁸ Ibid.

²⁹ Ibid., 77–79.

liturgical theology were a mother discipline to politics or economics, but nevertheless certain concrete implications for labor (among other things) do follow from centering liturgical theology on the mystical body of Christ, and the self-offering of Christians to God therein. For Michel, at least three insights flow from this integration of liturgy and labor: First, the power that governs the social body (government) has a legitimate role in regulating that body so that the particular members of the body can acquire and sustain “the means of a legitimate enjoyment of the good life.”³⁰ Social action to ensure that this power does so flows organically from liturgical practice—particularly the self-offering of Christians to God in the eucharistic sacrifice—because the mystical body of Christ is integrated with the social bodies of which Christians are part. Christians need not (indeed for Michel, *must* not) retreat from influencing government, insofar as that influence is to ensure that the conditions for the good life are available to all people. In Michel’s view this is not simply a political-theological claim; it is a liturgical-political claim.

Second, social justice is a Christian virtue that flows at least in part from liturgical celebration. Michel also calls social justice “the forgotten virtue,”³¹ but nevertheless maintains that justice in the social world is a liturgical concern. With regard to labor, this means that part of the work of the mystical body of Christ is to help ensure a just wage—defined as a living family wage³²—for all workers. Christians cannot be constituted liturgically as the mystical body of Christ, an action in which they symbolically offer themselves to God, and then be content with an economic body that harms its members or sustains them inadequately. To do so would be to embrace the disintegration heralded by bourgeois individualism. Just wages are also a liturgical concern.

Third, and perhaps most widely-encompassing, the exercise of Christianity—most especially Christian liturgy—should serve to infuse its cultural context with “the age-old inspiring and unifying spirit of Christian love.”³³ Michel

³⁰ Virgil Michel, “Government Regulation of Business,” in *Political Theories and Forms*, book 3 of *The Social Problem* (Collegeville, MN: Saint John’s Abbey, 1937), 33.

³¹ Michel, *Christian Social Reconstruction*, 13.

³² *Ibid.*, 35–37.

³³ Virgil Michel, “Christian Culture,” *Orationes Fratres* 13, no. 7 (1939): 300.

speaks of a kind of “Christian culture”—though explicitly *not* the “Christian” cultures of the past³⁴—whose chief characteristic is to infuse its context with justice and love.³⁵ His goal in this is to specifically preclude the idea that Christians as the mystical body of Christ should somehow reject or retreat from their cultural contexts in order to set up something different and apart: “The task of [Christians] today is not, however, to turn [their backs] on the entire culture of today. That would be an admission of cowardice and defeat.”³⁶ Instead, the liturgy shows Christians the integral whole of life, mandating an integrated approach to Christian life that includes liturgical practice, one’s work life, the culture of which one is a part, and essentially all other aspects of one’s existence. The disintegrated life of bourgeois individualism is anathema to Christianity, and most especially to Christian liturgy.

TOWARD A LITURGICAL THEOLOGY OF MEANINGFUL WORK

One might rightly ask a pointed practical question at this juncture: given this integrity of liturgy and labor, as well as the supposedly organic process of their integration, why isn’t the process more effective? A coherent and compelling approach to the connection between liturgy and labor is simply a museum piece if the processes of integration that it describes don’t actually happen to any discernible degree. In short, if Michel’s vision is to be taken seriously, what inhibits its realization in the context of the contemporary US church?

As Michel interpreted his own context, the major obstacles to integrating liturgical practice with concern and action for just and meaningful labor were the perennial problems of Christian apathy and lack of understanding of their

³⁴ Ibid.

³⁵ In this Michel would likely be appalled at the so-called “culture wars,” as they appear to have little to do with this central concern of the “spirit of Christian love.”

³⁶ Michel, “Christian Culture,” 299. It may be worthwhile to note that in this sense, Michel would have significant objections to projects such as Rod Dreher’s *The Benedict Option* (New York: Penguin Random House, 2017). It is also worthwhile noting that even when Michel speaks of conflicts between church and culture in the most stark terms, he does so in terms of engagement and ministry (even as spiritual battle), not as withdrawal. See, for example, Virgil Michel, “The Fight Against Communism,” *Orate Fratres* 11, no. 3 (1937): 125–28.

own tradition.³⁷ With more theological education and what the Benedictines call “good zeal,” greater integration of liturgical practice and the social and labor bodies could simply be part of Christians’ growth in the faith. However, beyond the perennial nature of those issues, there is at least one other major complicating factor that has complicated the contemporary US context in a way that it didn’t Michel’s. As Mary Collins quipped in 1991, “Virgil Michel’s world is not ours.”³⁸ Michel could, to a respectable degree, assume that the Christians (again, mostly Catholics for him) to whom he spoke would be fairly familiar with the systems of symbols within which his liturgical and sacramental theology worked. That would be far less the case today.³⁹ By this I do not mean that Christians of his day may have understood symbols in a deeper way than contemporary Christians (they may not have); instead, I mean that the very practices of Christians in Michel’s time included far more regular immersion in the symbolic and ritual systems of their faith than those of Christians today. Participation in liturgy and the communal life of the parish lived in a different mode and to a different degree in the early twentieth century than now in the early twenty-first.

This is not at all to say that significant theological work has not been done to retrieve liturgical and sacramental theologies of the symbol (and even sacrifice)—much indeed has⁴⁰—instead, I would argue that if Christians have trouble appreciating the symbolic within Christian liturgy itself, then the

³⁷ See, for example, Virgil Michel, “Catholic Leadership and the College,” *Orate Fratres* 10, no. 1 (1935): 23.

³⁸ Mary Collins, “Participation: Liturgical Renewal and the Cultural Question,” in *The Future of the Catholic Church in America: Major Papers of the Virgil Michel Symposium* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1991), 20.

³⁹ Examples of this abound, but one potent illustration is the recent Pew study that claimed that only 34 percent of US Catholics believe that “the bread and wine used for Communion are not symbolic, but actually become the body and blood of Jesus” (Pew Research Center, “What Americans Know About Religion,” accessed June 22, 2021, <https://www.pewforum.org/2019/07/23/what-americans-know-about-religion/>).

⁴⁰ The work of Louis-Marie Chauvet stands out in retrieval of theology of the symbol; see Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1995), especially parts 1, 2, and 3. For sacrifice, see especially Robert Daly, *Sacrifice Unveiled: The True Meaning of Christian Sacrifice* (New York: T&T Clark, 2009); and Edward Kilmartin, *The Eucharist in the West: History and Theology* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1998).

symbolic self-offering of labor in the service of God *outside* liturgy is more likely to strike Christians as fantasy than reality. This would be the central hurdle to overcome in crafting a liturgical theology of meaningful work: to build upon Michel's insights, the nexus point between liturgical practice and meaningful work is the integrated, symbolic self-offering of Christians to God, embodied in this world as the mystical body of Christ. It should be clear by this point that offering oneself to God, for Michel, is not simply a general spiritualized assent to the existence of the divine. Rather, this symbolic self-offering that takes place liturgically is to be lived out in the particular social circumstances in which Christians find themselves. This is what meaningful work would be for Michel; it is work that is *made meaningful* by the symbolic offering of that labor in the service of God, by Christians sacramentally connected with one another as the mystical body of Christ, whose life in the world should resemble the life of Christ: characterized by justice, love, and mercy.

A clarifying word is warranted regarding symbols and self-offering. A good deal of work has been done on the relationship between the symbolic and what it means to offer (or to give), and my conceptions here (and in the recommendations that follow) stand in the vein of understanding symbol and offering brought to the fore by Louis-Marie Chauvet.⁴¹ This is not a random choice; Chauvet's theology of symbol has already been connected to Michel's use of mystical body of Christ theology by other scholars,⁴² and it is most useful in staving off misunderstandings of both the symbol and the concept of offering (or gift). Very briefly, in Chauvet's conception, a symbol bears with it the presence of the one who offers it.⁴³ In a symbolic exchange then, what is exchanged is not simply the matter of a gift, but the givers themselves, and what is received is not simply a good or service, but the presence of the one giving it.⁴⁴

⁴¹ See Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament*, as well as his *Sacraments: Word of God at the Mercy of the Body* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2001).

⁴² For example, by Timothy Gabrielli (*One in Christ*, 182–83).

⁴³ Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament*, 123–24.

⁴⁴ *Ibid.*, 106–7.

To interpret Michel through this lens, one can see how the symbolic self-offering of Christians to God can take place liturgically and socially. In offering the gifts of bread and wine, the assembly offers its very self, and for Michel, in particular it offers the labor of its members.⁴⁵ The labor of the mystical body can then be thought of as symbolically consecrated in the celebration of the eucharist, and such a consecration cannot simply end at the close of the liturgy. The symbolic consecration of the labor of the mystical body of Christ endures just as surely as the real presence endures in the elements. As such, when the mystical body of Christ is sent forth from liturgy for life in the world, the workers who have been liturgically constituted as the mystical body of Christ have had their labor infused with meaning not by some recognition that it is somehow special or fulfilling to them personally, but because it has been offered and dedicated to the service of God. That, for Michel, is meaningful work, and it is infused with that meaning by the liturgical action of the mystical body of Christ.

Again, however, intellectual recognition of this process is wholly insufficient for the process to actually take place. Symbolization requires action—actually doing the symbolic exchange, not just thinking about it or recognizing it. So what can be done? In a context where the ritual symbols of Christianity—and the whole symbolic systems of language in which they operate—tend to be more and more remote from Christians themselves, of what use would be this kind of liturgical theology? Here again I believe Michel's insights are astute: just as liturgical theology cannot retreat from its social implications for concrete action, neither can liturgical theology rest only on its ideas and concepts without attending to how those ideas and concepts can take on flesh ritually and otherwise. In this spirit, this discussion closes with three practical suggestions for liturgical practice in order to more effectively provide infusion of meaning into the labor of Christians, one as a guiding principle, and two as recommendations for ritual practice itself.

⁴⁵ Michel, *Our Life in Christ*, 98. For Michel, more general economic and liturgical developments are also integrally related; see Virgil Michel, "The Cooperative Movement and the Liturgical Movement," *Orate Fratres* 14, no. 4 (1940): 152–60.

The guiding principle I would suggest is this: work to retrieve the language and content of symbolization on a popular level. It hardly needs to be said that the word “symbol” and its derivatives are often seen as opposed to reality (the more symbolic something is, the less real it is). The reasons for this are numerous, but retrieving a popular understanding of symbol as not opposed to but instead embodying reality in particular ways would (re-)open whole conceptual worlds within which the mystical body of Christ can re-acquaint itself with its nature and mission. This need not be a radical liturgical move. Simply using the word symbol in connection with self-offering or sacrifice could start to erode the fear and distaste wrongly associated with it. I do not say this is without risk, but in communities where good faith can be cultivated between liturgical leaders and the assemblies they serve, such a risk can be mitigated both by catechesis and conversation on the one hand, and by contextualizing this way of speaking within the liturgy on the other. In a word, getting folks comfortable with symbols and their reality (again) would be a principle to guide the liturgical infusion of meaning into Christian labor.

Second, preaching and praying about the symbolic offering of labor in the service of God would make it ritually explicit in ways that the systems of symbols currently often leave implicit. The prayers of the people would be an essential place to do this, helping folks to see and pray for their own labor and the labor of their neighbors, and would help to bring into focus the symbolization of labor prior to the actual offering of the community’s gifts at the altar. This, bolstered by at least intermittent attention in preaching, could go a long way in helping regular liturgical attendees to recognize and make more real what is already implicit: the religious meaning of their work. This of course is exactly the weakness of this second suggestion, however: it rests on regular liturgical attendance. However, as the COVID pandemic recedes, many church communities have found ways of virtually reaching folks that they were not able to before. Such avenues can be used as pedagogical in much the same way that Michel saw the liturgy as pedagogical,⁴⁶ and good pedagogy is very often also invitation. Regular liturgical attendance is ideal, but in circumstances where it

⁴⁶ Michel, “Teaching the Life of Christ,” 12–17.

is not possible or not common, the mystical body of Christ nevertheless cannot abandon its members.

Third and finally, increased use of blessings for labor, workplaces, and jobs in general would help to bridge the gap between the ritual infusion of meaning into labor accomplished at the liturgy of the eucharist and the actual living out of Christians' work-lives. Michel himself speaks of the blessings of the field and factory⁴⁷ as a worthwhile aspect of Christian liturgical life; these sacramentals need not be rare sidenotes to the liturgical life of a community. Imagine if it were regular Christian practice to bless particular members of the assembly whenever they land a new job, or to regularly bless new businesses around the parish. This could of course be received as the church "sticking its nose" into non-liturgical functions, but that's exactly the point. All of Christian life, with thanks to Michel, should be as worship, and a promising way of moving in that direction would simply be to place liturgies (sacramentals) at important points of development in the work-lives of Christians. Let the Christian meaning of labor become explicit, so that for Christians it becomes obvious and an essential aspect of their lives as part of the mystical body of Christ.

CONCLUSION

This discussion, after describing Virgil Michel's approach to the theology of the mystical body of Christ and the bourgeois individualism he saw as catalyzing its disintegration, has argued that Christians' labor can be newly infused with meaning by retrieving the symbolic connection between Christians' liturgical self-offering in the service of God and their offerings of labor in that same service. Such a connection would rely on re-centering the liturgical (and social) theology of the mystical body of Christ, which for Michel holds the key to the integrative character of all of Christian life. As Christians are formed into the one mystical body of Christ in liturgy, so also are they members of the same mystical body as they undertake their daily labor. Re-formation in this reality would work to clarify for Christians both the necessity of justice and Christian love in the workplace, and the religious meaning of their work.

⁴⁷ Michel, *Our Life in Christ*, 187. See also Virgil Michel, *The Liturgy of the Church According to the Roman Rite* (New York: MacMillan, 1937), 267–73.

Work does not derive meaning from profit; work derives meaning from the building up of the mystical body of Christ, and from reaching out in love as that mystical body to a hurting world that needs its action in mercy and justice. Work, seen from a liturgical perspective, is symbolically ordered to loving the neighbor and the world as Christ loves them; it is ordered, in the words of the motto of Virgil Michel's Benedictine Order, *ut in omnibus glorificetur Deus*.⁴⁸

⁴⁸ That in all things God may be glorified.

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